

Richmond approves new surveillance camera contract, delays ALPR decision

City lawmakers select new vendor in move away from Flock



By **SIERRA LOPEZ** | slopez@bayareanewsgroup.com | Bay Area News Group

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RICHMOND — While still uncertain about the efficacy of automatic license plate readers, councilmembers again delayed adopting a new ALPR contract while allowing an agreement for drones and other surveillance cameras to move forward.

In a 5-2 vote Tuesday night, the Richmond City Council renewed and expanded a contract with Axon, an Arizona-based weapons and technology manufacturer. The company already provides services to the

Under the renewed contract, Axon will also become the city's primary surveillance system provider, taking over CCTV and drone services from Flock Safety.

Automatic license plate reader (ALPR) cameras were not included in this new agreement.

Councilmembers delayed a vote on an ALPR portion of the contract for the second time Tuesday — the [first time](#) was late last month — again citing concerns about how the city's data will be protected and secured and an interest in learning more about how effective the cameras are at preventing and solving crime.

Lawmakers requested the ALPR contract be brought back at a future meeting for further review.

"It will be the best step for the city of Richmond to take the bold approach of looking into a secure solution for the data," Councilmember Soheila Bana said during the Tuesday meeting.

"It's not easy. It's very difficult. It may be expensive. It may take time. But we have the courage and intention to do that."

Richmond has been searching for a new ALPR vendor since February after Richmond Police Chief Tim Simmons disabled Flock's cameras late last year out of concern for data security.

The department had been using Flock's "national lookup" feature that allows agencies to search license plate data from other agencies using the company's system.

Simmons said the department used the feature to search outside the city's data but were not informed by Flock that enabling "national lookup" also allowed outside agencies to access Richmond's data. Richmond did appear in other agency's queries, but there's no evidence that data was pulled or used, he noted.

Flock has provided ALPR cameras to the city since 2023. What started out as a contract for 30 ALPR cameras evolved into a \$2 million agreement for

more than 150 cameras, including 110 automatic license plate readers, 60

Councilmembers [decided](#) in March to turn the license plate readers back on and to extend its contract with Flock through the end of the year, with the understanding that a replacement vendor would be selected by then.

ALPR camera systems have received strong pushback from communities, activists and politicians nationwide across political parties after stories of data abuse have come to light. Officers have been accused of using ALPR data to stalk other people and inaccurately accuse people of crimes.

In Richmond, activists and residents have also raised concerns about the data being used for mass deportation operations or tracking people seeking abortions who come from states where the medical treatment is illegal.

Hundreds of cities nationwide have either dropped or are reviewing their contracts with Flock over similar concerns. Locally, those jurisdictions include Mountain View, San Jose, Antioch, Hayward and the counties of Santa Clara and Alameda.

“The benefits are unproven and the harms are documented,” Sarah Hamid, director of strategic campaigns for the Electronic Frontier Foundation, a digital civil liberties watchdog, said during a presentation to the council Tuesday.

“Given how pervasive, sprawling and ungovernable ALPR sharing networks have become, the only feature update we can truly rely on to protect people’s safety and rights is no network at all.”

Others argued during the meeting that the ALPR camera system is an invaluable tool that has helped [an understaffed Richmond Police Department](#) solve crime.

Ben Therriault, the president of the Richmond Police Officers Association, said arguments about how the cameras can be used to harm Black and Brown communities is “fear-mongering” and “hysteria” that doesn’t accurately represent how the system is used locally.

“We need to move forward so that we can have another avenue to help victims of crime in this city,” he said.

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